



Southern South America

TOWERING MOUNTAINS, vast grassy plains, and hot deserts create a very diverse geographical landscape. The four countries in this region—Chile, Paraguay, Uruguay, and Argentina—were once Spanish colonies but gained their independence in the early 1800s. Each country has an elected government but their economies remain fragile. Most of the population speak Spanish and are mestizo—of mixed Spanish and native Indian descent—except for Argentina, where up to 97 percent are descended from Europeans.

ATACAMA DESERT

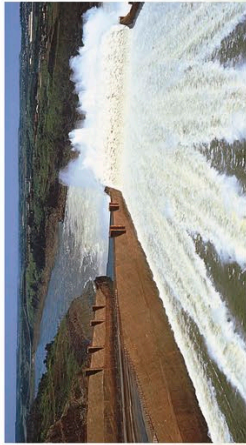
Sandwiched between the high Andes and the sea, the Atacama Desert in northern Chile is one of the hottest and driest areas in the world. Rain hardly ever falls here. This harsh landscape, however, is rich in copper deposits.



CHILEAN EDUCATION

Chile has a relatively high literacy rate (ability to read and write). This may be because between the ages of 6 and 18 schooling is both free and compulsory.

South America



ITAIPÚ DAM

The enormous Itaipu dam on the Paraná River in Paraguay is one of the world's largest hydroelectric projects. It generates 75 percent of the electricity Paraguay needs as well as large amounts for export.

A mix of Colonial Spanish, Italian, and Art Deco styles of architecture shows Montevideo's rich history.



URUGUAY'S CAPITAL

The capital of Uruguay, Montevideo, is home to nearly half the country's population. It is also the main port and economic center. This lively capital lies on the east bank of the Río de la Plata, and is a popular holiday resort because of its white sandy beaches.

